

Pelanomodon

PEL-an-OH-mow-don

- **When** 255 million years ago (Late Permian)
- **Fossil location** S. Africa
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Pelanomodon was a member of a large and very successful family of plant-eating therapsids called the dicynodonts (DIE-CYE-no-donts). The dicynodonts used toothless beaks to pluck vegetation, and most had a single pair of tusks. *Pelanomodon* was a stocky, piglike dicynodont that had no tusks. Like other dicynodonts, it could slide its lower jaw forward and backward, which helped it grind the tough plants it ate.



Pitted beak bone

◀ FINE FOSSIL

In this remarkably well-preserved Pelanomodon skull, the bone around the beak has lots of tiny holes where blood vessels once ran.

Robertia

roe-BERT-ee-ah

- **When** 255 million years ago (Late Permian)
- **Fossil location** S. Africa
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 1 ft (0.4 m)
- **Diet** Plants



The earliest dicynodont known from good fossils is *Robertia*. This small plant-eater was about the size of a domestic cat and had a turtlelike beak, which it used to crop leaves. It had a pair of tusks formed from canine teeth and perhaps used them to dig for roots.

Placerias

plah-SEE-ree-ass

- **When** 220–215 million years ago (Late Triassic)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Flood plains
- **Length** 6–11 ft (2–3 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Placerias was one of the biggest herbivores of its day, weighing about 1,300 lb (600 kg). One of the last large dicynodonts, it lived at the same time as early dinosaurs. Similar in shape and weight to a hippo, it might have wallowed in water, too, and may have used its tusks for fights and social displays as hippos do. A find of 40 skeletons in one place suggests *Placerias* lived in herds.



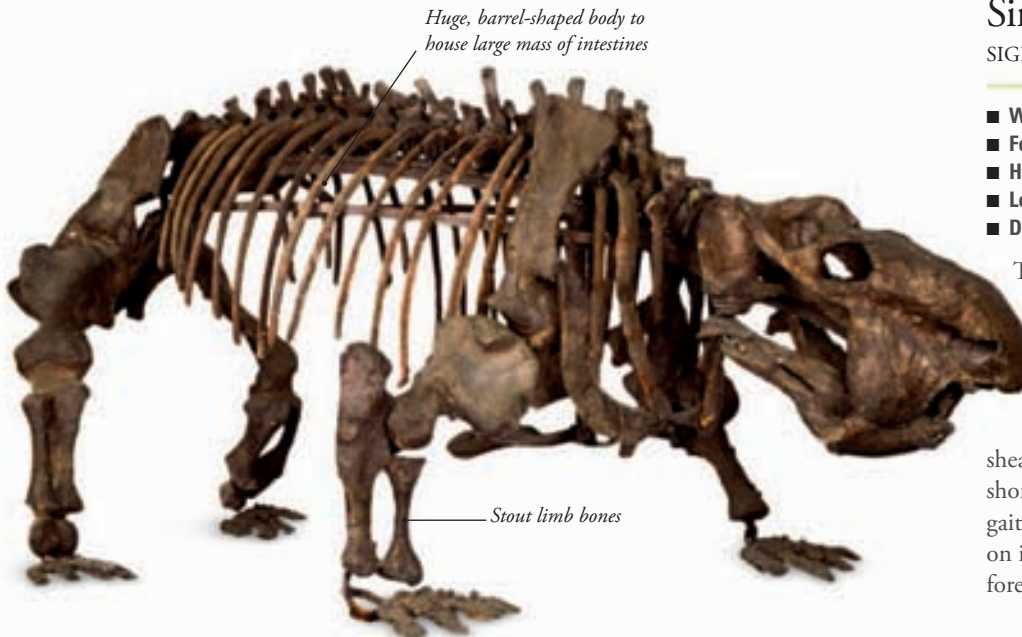
Broad feet with blunt claws

Sinokannemeyeria

SIGH-no-CAN-eh-my-AIR-ee-ah

- **When** 235 million years ago (Middle Triassic)
- **Fossil location** China
- **Habitat** Woodland
- **Length** 6 ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Tough vegetation, roots

This pig-sized dicynodont had a massive head, a long snout, and a huge belly to house the large intestines needed for digesting rough plant material. Like other dicynodonts, it could move its lower jaw forward and backward to shear and grind tough leaves. Its legs were short and stumpy, with a slightly sprawling gait, suggesting it was not very fast or agile on its feet. But it may have used its powerful forelimbs and small tusks to dig for roots.



Huge, barrel-shaped body to house large mass of intestines

Stout limb bones

